Effects of pollution

Two main types of pollution damage marine ecosystems. Runoff from fertilizers is a common problem: the nitrogen and phosphorus that many contain produce algal blooms (overgrowths of algae, or phytoplankton), which later die. As they decompose, they take up oxygen, creating a “dead zone” in the water that cannot sustain life. Because fish must leave such water or perish, juvenile fish living close to the shore are at risk before they move into the open ocean. In 2017, the annual dead zone in the Gulf of Mexico was more than 8,500 sq miles (22,000 sq km). Plastic pollution is another threat because fish eat it and get caught in nets and debris. Estimates suggest between 1 and 1.7 million metric tons of plastic enters the ocean each year. This is a result of plastic leaked into the environment and transported to the ocean. It is estimated that 19 million metric tons of plastic is leaked into the environment annually.